

hours might spend as a way to make up for a lack of leisure time, or for missing out on good company and rest. Someone feeling disconnected from friends and family, especially following the long months of isolation and loneliness that kicked off the 2020s, might spend as a way to assuage or quieten those feelings. If we can find a way to visualize this, and to tap into those gaps in our true self-care that we all know are there, deep down, then we should be able to start taking care of our wellbeing in a more comprehensive and authentic way, and remove the need for expensive sticking plasters and distractions.

Exercise: Your hierarchy

Can you start now? Consider Maslow's hierarchy and sketch out your own, thinking about what you need to feel whole and well. Look at the places where there are gaps and think about the role that those gaps play in your relationship with money. Is there something making you feel unsafe, that makes you afraid to spend a single penny, or obsessed with checking your bank balance? Is there something that you perceive to be missing elsewhere that you feel the need to compensate for with overspending – such as home-ownership or employment? Refer to the different tiers in Maslow's model, and really see if you can create a meaningful reference for understanding your spending behaviour.